

When Identity Becomes Political

A proposed randomized survey experiment on multiracial identity and political alignment

A causal research design asking whether temporarily activating different dimensions of racial identity changes political attitudes among multiracial adults.

QUESTION AND APPROACH

The proposed study would recruit 1,200 adults who identify as White and at least one non-White racial group. Participants would be randomly assigned to a minority-identity prime, a White-identity prime, or a neutral control. Common outcome measures include linked fate, group closeness, racial resentment, policy preferences, partisan identification, and affective group evaluations.

CONTRIBUTION

The design defines identity activation as a specific causal mechanism rather than treating race as one fixed variable. It sets out three competing possibilities—minority solidarity, assimilative alignment, and an emergent multiracial orientation—and specifies OLS estimation with robust standard errors, balance checks, manipulation checks, and subgroup analyses.

SELECTED TAKEAWAYS

- Random assignment can identify short-term effects of identity salience if the primes work as intended and experimental balance is achieved.
- The design deliberately separates group membership, stable identity strength, and situational salience.
- The narrowed sample improves causal clarity but limits generalizability; a short survey prime cannot establish durable real-world change.

SKILLS DEMONSTRATED

- Theory building, survey experiment design, measurement, hypothesis development, and causal-inference reasoning
- Ethical framing of sensitive identity research and transparent distinction between a proposal and completed empirical findings

Portfolio note: This is a research-design proposal; no data were collected and no results are claimed. To request the full paper, contact Caleb at johnston.caleb325@gmail.com.